India and Bangladesh. In the past few years, forced repatriation has increased and significant human rights abuses have been documented. Many of the refugees living in neighboring Bangladesh have been seized, beaten, and forced back into Myanmar. Accusations of anti-Muslim discrimination are commonplace. The Myanmar authorities claim that the Rohingya are not indigenous to the country and are treated as non-citizens.

Shan

The Shan state is the most ethnically diverse region in all of Myanmar. Ten or more ethnic groups constitute a population base of over 100,000, all with different languages and cultural characteristics. Historically, the Shan state included over 40 princely substates who constantly vied for regional control. The internal fighting in the Shan area impeded economic development in the region. At the time of independence, the Shan area was promised the right to secede after the first 10 years. From the time of independence, the Shan area was beset with conflict. From the incursion of Chinese nationalist forces in the 1950s to the separatist movements within Myanmar, the Shan area has remained constantly embroiled in conflict. Further conflict within the region centered on the Communist Party of Burma gaining support from Mao Zedong in the late 1960s. Liberated zones were established numerous times and in places in the Shan area. By the late 1980s, the main source of income for many residents of the Shan state was opium production. The changing global environment complicated the political situation in the Shan region. The Communist Party of Burma lost support and quickly disintegrated. The Shan did participate in the 1990 elections, winning 23 legislative seats. The election results did not halt the fighting within the region. The refugee crisis in the Shan state is overwhelming, with nearly 500,000 IDPs or refugees reported by the late 1990s. Forced conscription of the civilian population is also commonplace. Child soldiers are also forcibly recruited by the tatmadaw. Shan women have also been prey for the sex industry in neighboring Thailand. HIV numbers among the returning women is alarmingly high. Furthermore, numerous members of the tatmadaw from the Shan state mutinied from the government, forming the United Wa State Party.

The Myanmar authorities and the Shan political leaders give radically different numbers regarding the percentage of the population that is part of